was an increase in population and more food was needed. Kongo became one of the biggest states in western central Africa as it covered territory from the Atlantic in the west all the way to the Kwango River.

Kongo's system of Manikongo succession was often problematic. The position was generally transferred from father to son but there were often disputes between the sons and brothers of former kings. Kongo had a court where political matters would be discussed and it was supported by an extensive network of civil servants. The court consisted of relatives of the king including the governors of various villages.

Before becoming Christian, the people from the Kongo Kingdom believed in a supreme god named Nzambi. They also believed in intermediary representations such as land, sky and ancestral spirits, all of which were portrayed in nkisi objects. The people often consulted a “nganga” (diviner) if they felt hardship or felt that they had insulted a spirit. This nganga would usually instruct them to add some medicine into certain nkisi to achieve well-being and recovery.

When the Portuguese arrived in Kongo in 1483, both the Manikongo and his son were baptized and given Christian names. Strong bonds were formed between the kingdom of Kongo and Portugal. Some nobles from Kongo were taken to Portugal and some Portuguese went to live in the kingdom of Kongo. A Roman Catholic Church was built to transmit the Christian religion in the territory. Also, during the years that followed, Kongo became the primary source of slaves not just for Portugal but for most of Europe.

The Portuguese were attracted by the gold mines the Kongo possessed. This relationship that they had formed with the people of Kongo enabled them to exploit and trade those goods. Due to their lust for more slaves and gold, the Portuguese ended up disrupting the peace they had with the people of Kongo. In 1526, the Portuguese were expelled from the territory. However, the Jagas invaded the kingdom of Kongo in 1568 and the Kongo was forced to ask the Portuguese for help. The Kongo kingdom never regained power